

BEYOND TECHNICAL SKILLS: UNDERSTANDING EMPLOYABILITY SKILLS DEVELOPMENT THROUGH GRADUATE LEARNERSHIP PROGRAMMES IN SOUTH AFRICA

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Abstract

Graduate employability has been a pressing concern in South Africa, as many graduates lack the skills to translate their academic qualifications into labour market readiness. Although the emergence of learnerships has become an important policy instrument in facilitating this transition, a significant portion of the existing literature on the topic focuses on programme outcomes and employers' views rather than graduates' developmental experiences. However, limited research exists on how graduates specifically understand and develop employability skills within the learnership. Addressing this gap, this paper will integrate the theoretical concept of employability with empirical data on skills development to conceptualise the development of employability skills through the Graduate Learnership Programme. The overarching question is: How do graduates conceptualise and develop employability skills through learnership programmes? A qualitative design was employed, utilising three focus group discussions and open-ended surveys with graduates from two organisations offering learnerships. Thematic analysis was used to investigate how participants understood employability, the skills they valued, and how these abilities developed through formal learning and workplace exposure. The results indicate that communication, analytical thinking, problem-solving, teamwork, confidence, and professionalism were the most valued competencies. Graduates highlighted that these abilities were learned more through real-world tasks, interaction in organisations, and reflective practice than through formal teaching. The unemployed reported very few skills developments, which accords centrality to experiential learning. The paper will argue that employability skills development in learnership programmes is a dynamic process influenced by both structured learning and workplace experiences. It is necessary to reconceptualise our understanding of skills development, support it, and inform future programme design, policy alignment, and industry collaboration.

Keywords: Graduate employability; learnership programmes; workplace learning; Skills development.

1 INTRODUCTION

Graduate unemployment is one of the most chronic socio-economic problems in South Africa. However, regardless of formal qualifications, several young graduates are unable to successfully transition into the labour market (Allais, 2022). The problem persists as employers continue to prioritise work preparedness and soft skills, including communication, adaptability, teamwork, and problem-solving, over technical academic competencies (Winberg et al., 2020). To address this gap, it is necessary to adopt a more nuanced view of how employability skills are developed, exercised, and translated into professional identity and labour-market entry.

Work-Based Learning (WBL) in South Africa is referred to as Learnership programmes, which consist of structured learning and work placements. These programmes aim to enhance the labour-market preparation of unemployed youth (Department of Higher Education and Training [DHET], 2019; Mayombe, 2023). Although learnerships have become a policy intervention to deal with youth unemployment (Allais, 2022), much less is known about how graduates themselves frame the concept of employability in the learnership model, the way they learn and apply critical work-related skills, and how their understanding of this concept changes throughout the course of the intervention.

This paper examines the lived experiences of graduates in developing employability skills within the context of learnership programmes. Basing it on a theorisation of employability as a dynamic variable of flow (Winberg et al., 2020), it suggests that learning in learnerships is not passively acquired through instruction, but rather iterative, relational, and embedded in workplace practice.

2 METHODOLOGY

This is a qualitative study of two organisations in South Africa that offer learnerships across various fields, including finance, ICT, and business support. They were recently graduated learners, having completed learnerships in 2021-2023.

Data collection was conducted based on responses to online open-ended questionnaires and three virtual focus group discussions. The qualitative data comprise 64 participants' responses to OEQs and observations from three online FGDs with graduates, which were analysed thematically, as reported in the empirical source. This will provide a rich source of insight into how graduates develop throughout their graduate years.

The study was conducted in accordance with ethical standards, as participants provided informed consent and anonymity was ensured through coded identifiers (including OEQs and FGD), thereby ensuring the authenticity of the data. The institutional review board of the original researcher had provided ethical clearance, and participation was voluntary; no personal information was collected.

2.1 Ethical Considerations

Approval to conduct this study was obtained from the Human Research Ethics Committee (Non-Medical) of the University of the Witwatersrand, Johannesburg. Voluntary consent was obtained from the participants via a consent form. All 74 respondents (64 OEQs and 10 FGD) confirmed that they had read and fully understood the consent form and that they willingly chose to participate in this research study.

3 RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

3.1 Graduate Skills Identify as Most Valuable

Communication, teamwork, analytical thinking, professionalism and self-confidence were also core employability skills that graduates repeatedly emphasised. Whereas technical skills were necessary, soft skills determined success in the workplace, especially in organisational cultures that emphasised teamwork, initiative, and the ability to respond quickly to evolving work needs. These skills have not been viewed as discrete skills but as a set that interacts with one another to enable good performance in work environments. Learnership was a key area where these capabilities were realised, reinforced, and perfected for many graduates (Winberg et al., 2020; Nkwanyane et al., 2022). Thus, it is essential to systematise workplace exposure by addressing the gap between theory and practice.

The ability to express oneself clearly, professionally, and confidently is a vital skill, particularly in communication. Graduates have observed that their capacity to be perceived and respected in the workplace directly depends on how well they communicate with others.

"Communication skills... I noticed that I have professional growth in the way I articulated myself and carried myself."

According to the graduates, communication was built through continuous professional contacts, instead of in the classroom, and they trained and developed through meetings, presentations, and informal conversations. They stated that they had started to notice improvements in verbal expression, clarity of thought, and confidence in their ideas, as communication is a skill that improves with experience and constant use. Most graduates associate communication with its direct impact on success in teamwork, client dealings, and leadership prospects, and they stated that their technical knowledge was insufficient to achieve professional success without effective communication (Winberg et al., 2020; Havenga & Swart, 2022).

Teamwork was also cited as a valuable skill, especially in team setups where graduates were likely to work with teammates with diverse backgrounds and varying levels of expertise. The ability to be a productive team member, a good listener, and to make valuable contributions to the team was considered key to establishing strong professional relationships and staying productive. According to the graduates, respect, humility, and cooperation are crucial in group work settings, as teamwork enables them to learn and gain confidence in their own contributions (Havenga & Swart, 2022; Winberg et al., 2022).

Critical and problem-solving skills were also considered necessary, especially in jobs that require graduates to handle complex tasks, analyse information, and make decisions.

"I had to use analytical skills, critical thinking skills, problem-solving skills and communication skills."

Graduates perceived the skills as key to accomplishing tasks effectively and taking initiative. They explained analytical thinking as the skill of deconstructing problems, taking other perspectives, and finding a way out. This mental ability was enhanced through practical assignments, critical appraisals, and in-the-job decision-making procedures gained through workplace exposure. Graduates noted that they were able to develop these skills not only through learning but also in their everyday lives and when they needed to apply theoretical knowledge to concrete situations.

Another core competency that surfaced was professionalism, particularly in terms of workplace behaviour, deadline management, effective time management, and maintaining a positive attitude. Graduates observed that professionalism was not only about completing tasks, but also about being reliable and accountable, as well as presenting themselves professionally. They explained that their compliance with workplace standards and expectations helped them become part of organisational cultures and establish trust with supervisors and fellow staff.

Confidence was also regarded as a key skill that is nurtured over time through workplace exposure. Graduates commented that they joined the programme without knowing what to expect of professional life but slowly gained confidence as they engaged in organisational operations and through their errors.

"When I joined... I was clueless... now the confidence in myself is there... I would express myself differently."

Graduates considered these skills core to accomplishing assignments effectively and with diligence. These descriptions, which transform uncertainty into self-belief, support their student identity as it evolves into an emergent professional identity, reinforcing the fact that emotional and psychological development are at the centre of employability.

Skills that enable graduates to articulate their thoughts, think flexibly, and be confident in their profession are valued assets, not just academic knowledge. This supports the demands of graduate development forms that emphasise adaptive capabilities and holistic professional development. Their considerations suggest that employability skills cannot be viewed as fixed abilities but rather as dynamic ones developed through practice, real-life interactions, and critical thinking.

3.2 Workplace Exposure Influencing Employability Skill Development

Exposure to the workplace appeared to be the most potent factor in shaping employability skills, with graduates continually stressing the significance of real-life experience in developing their confidence, competence, and professional identity. Although formal learning and theoretical knowledge provided graduates with a starting point, they viewed the workplace as the most critical place where skills could not only be applied but also tested, refined, and internalised. It is an exceptional contribution of learnerships as a paradigm that integrates academic learning and experience, allowing graduates to bridge the gap between theoretical knowledge and practical skills.

Graduates reported that working in real-world settings enabled them to escape the abstract demands of academic work, learning to understand the effects of their actions on organisational operations, clients, and peers. This exposure ensured a better understanding of the expectations and performance standards in the workplace, as well as the professional behaviour necessary for competitiveness. Most graduates indicated that direct participation in work activities helped them build resilience, initiative, and problem-solving skills in areas that would not have been covered through traditional classroom-based learning. These findings align with evidence that authentic, collaborative work-integrated contexts help students internalise workplace standards, develop professional behaviour, and strengthen problem-solving beyond classroom learning (Havenga & Swart, 2022; Winberg et al., 2022).

One graduate reflected on the reality of workplace consequences, drawing a clear distinction between academic assessment and applied professional accountability:

"What you do [at work] has real world implication. It's not just if you don't necessarily get something right, you going to come out with a lower mark."

This transition between academic implications and practical outcomes fostered a greater sense of responsibility and awareness, underscoring the importance of workplace exposure as a learning process. Working with professionals, being guided, and performing actual work tasks also contributed to growth not only in skill acquisition but also in work ethic, work mindset, and identity building.

Workplaces have always been described as places of transformation where employability competencies are developed and enhanced through daily practice. As one participant explained:

"Workplaces as sites of learning ... enhances the development of employability skills."

The graduates emphasised that these settings provided opportunities to learn at various levels, including observing professional behaviour, collaborating with colleagues, working under deadlines, and contributing to problem-solving. To most of them, the work environment reflected their strengths, weaknesses, and possible career directions.

Another obvious result of workplace participation was increased confidence. Graduates who were exposed went beyond ignorance and confusion to being more comfortable in professional situations, as seen in the following reflection statement:

"Cause honestly, when I joined [the learnership], I was clueless about what goes on in the workplace. Now, even the confidence in myself is there ... I would express myself differently."

Although these experiences were positive, those graduates who had not secured a workplace placement were frustrated, disappointed, and felt that they had lost out. Their comments highlight the significance of workplace access in the learnership model. As one respondent stated:

"Unfortunately, I never got the opportunity to apply anything I learned, since I was never given the opportunity to be at workplace."

Another added:

"No skills acquired; I came out of the learnership same way I entered."

These narratives demonstrate that theoretical knowledge alone is insufficient to develop employability competence without practical application. The actual working environments equipped graduates with opportunities to practice, receive feedback, and gain confidence, which are essential elements of employability.

The outcome indicates that workplace exposure during the learnership was identified as a crucial trigger of skills acquisition, personal growth, and professional change. The graduates' reflections show that the real working environment encourages competencies beyond technical knowledge, encompassing communication, problem-solving, resilience, and professional identity. These experiences affirm that workplace participation is crucial in providing graduates with the readiness needed to succeed in the labour market.

3.3 Graduates' Perceptions of Employability Skills Throughout the Learnership Experience

The perceptions of employability skills underwent a significant transformation among the graduates during the learnership period. At the start of the programme, the participants had little knowledge of what employability was, and most could associate it only with academic qualifications or technical skills acquired in a higher institution. Nevertheless, after being exposed to workplaces and actual work commitments, their understanding of employability evolved into a broader, dynamic one. They started to realise that employability skills were not innate qualities they possessed upon graduation, but instead were continuously developing abilities refined through practice, experience, and contemplation. This shift mirrors research that frames employability as a developmental, practice-shaped capability as opposed to a fixed graduate attribute, deepened through real work exposure (Winberg et al., 2020; Nofemela & Winberg, 2020)

Graduates found employability to be a process of development that occurred over time, through interactions with the workforce, supervisor feedback, and exposure to workplace challenges. They realised that the learnership provided a platform for them to be transformed into graduate students with a theoretical understanding, enabling them to become professionals who can meet workplace expectations, manage their duties, and demonstrate initiative. They became more confident as they went through and realised the significance of soft skills, flexible and professional communication, and technical knowledge.

One participant powerfully captured this sense of development and identity transition by stating:

"Individuals stepping out of gradueness into a professional identity..."

Graduates came to perceive employability as a place of practical practice, not necessarily of academic success. They observed that confidence, communication in the workplace, and adaptation and

collaboration were the skills developed through repeated practices in actual work environments. Gradually, they were more advanced in their understanding of how the competencies helped them prepare to work.

Another graduate articulated this perspective by reflecting on the dynamic nature of skills development:

“Skills like communication and teamwork are dynamic... evolve through the programme.”

This identification aligns with the notion that employability is not a static condition but a continuous learning process. The graduates identified that real-life experiences, positive feedback, and lessons learned through errors in the favourable working environments helped them develop personally and professionally. They reported feeling a sense of agency and competence as they began to view themselves more as fledgling professionals, instead of inexperienced graduates.

The development of confidence was also a significant point of discussion, with numerous participants emphasising how exposure in a real workplace changed their self-belief and their voice in professional settings. One individual shared:

“I’m a different person compared to the last [year].”

This transformation promotes the value of experiential learning and identity construction towards enhancing employability. Graduates gained confidence and competence by acknowledging and addressing their weaknesses in the workplace and taking responsibility for them. Their changing perceptions testify to the replacement of the prior view of employability as a collection of qualifications by the current one, which emphasises a mixture of personal development, self-efficacy, and demonstrated ability to perform in the workplace.

The changing perceptions of graduates suggest that employability is developed over time through exposure, learning, interaction, and personal reflection. The learner model played a crucial role in facilitating this transition, as it provided meaningful interaction with the professional world. Graduates left behind the perception of themselves merely as students and began to see themselves as potential players in their organisations, ready to enter the labour market with more useful competencies, confidence, and a better sense of professional identity. This finding is consistent with work-integrated learning research, which shows that structured workplace participation helps students reframe themselves from learners to emerging professionals by building confidence, identity, and labour-market-relevant competencies (Winberg et al., 2022; Mbele & Swart, 2024).

3.4 Research Implications and Practice Recommendations

Employability does not exist at graduation but is acquired gradually through experience, exposure, and involvement in the actual working environment. Through meaningful workplace engagement, communication, analytical thinking, teamwork, confidence, and professional conduct have been enhanced, instead of through classroom instruction. It favours a relational and iterative view of employability and warrants research that considers it a socially constructed and dynamic capability.

Participation in the workplace was found to be the most critical activity, with the graduates reporting that professional identity was strengthened by genuine work, group interaction, supervision, and role modelling. This indicates the need to review the organisational learning context, including guidance, feedback, and opportunities to take on incremental responsibility, so that learnerships may be better prepared to gain employability.

There is also a need for greater alignment between workplace requirements and curricula. Applied learning, reflective activities, peer collaboration, and industry-informed assessments should be part of students' preparation for working with universities and training providers before placement. Mentorship, meaningful work, and frequent feedback should be incorporated into the placement by employers, as placements lacking these elements have been found to result in lower employability development. Disparate access to placements has been an issue that can be addressed through joint efforts among universities, skills regulators, and employers to increase and equitably allocate work-based learning opportunities, particularly for disadvantaged learners.

Mentoring and positive work environments help graduates learn from their mistakes and develop independence, thereby feeding talent pipelines. Research should question power relations, gatekeeping, and cultural dynamics that influence access to meaningful tasks and confidence-building opportunities to reinforce equity in learnerships in the future. Higher education, employers, and policy should work together to advance employability, thereby maintaining the quality of experiential learning and enhancing graduate transitions.

Table 1: Summary of key findings from the data with their illustrative quotes

Objectives	Key findings	Illustrative quote
Employability skills that graduates consider most valuable in learnership programmes	Soft skills, such as communication, teamwork, analytical thinking, professionalism, and confidence, were regarded as more critical than technical skills and were strengthened through participation in workplace activities.	“Communication skills... I noticed that I have professional growth in the way I articulated myself and carried myself.”
Workplace exposure contributes to the development of employability skills	Workplace exposure was the primary driver of employability development because real tasks, supervision and interaction helped graduates apply what they learned and build confidence, while a lack of placement limited growth.	“What you do at work has real world implication. It's not just if you don't get something right you get a lower mark.”
Graduates' perceptions of employability change through the learnership	Graduates' understanding of employability evolved from viewing it as a static outcome of education to seeing it as a dynamic process linked to identity, experience and continuous learning.	“I'm a different person compared to the last year.”

4 CONCLUSION

These results indicate that the success of employability transition in learnership programmes extends far beyond the acquisition of technical skills; it is a dynamic, iterative process influenced by meaningful workplace exposure, relational learning, and identity transformation. Communication, analytical skills, confidence, and professionalism were the main competencies identified by graduates, built not on theory but on location, feedback, and action in real organisational work. Experience in work environments enabled graduates to transition from knowledge holders to new professionals who can meet expectations and add value to organisational objectives. Notably, respondents who were not placed reported experiencing less growth, which highlights the critical role of practical experience in achieving employability. Learnerships are essential mechanisms for developing graduate readiness, enhancing soft-skill capacity, and fostering identity development. To maximise impact, programmes should guarantee access to the workplace, robust mentoring systems, and reflective learning opportunities that support learnerships as an essential entry-level to sustainable work.

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